

[ART: COVER]

Fortune or Death!

Crows is unfair. It doesn't care about your character's level. Charge at a behemoth without a good plan to take it down, and you're probably going to end up as a puddle of gore. This game's math hasn't been balanced to ensure players win most of the time or to ensure that each player character starts with the same level of power as the others.

But the unfairness goes both ways. Come with a clever plan to defeat that behemoth, like dropping the cave ceiling on their head while they slumber, and you can win the day without a fight. A good plan or clever thinking won't just save your life, it'll get you paid—and that's the whole point. Your life will be easier and you'll still get the gold and the XP if you can just sneak by that behemoth with your pockets full of coins.

In *Crows*, the players create adventurers in a desolate world who dive into horror-infested ruins for gold, gems, and other treasures. Sure, these adventurers occasionally perform courageous, selfless acts and might be moral people, but they aren't heroes. It's greed, thrill-seeking, or lack of other ways to make a living that drives them into the dark where gold and ravenous eyes gleam in the torchlight. It's a risky job—surviving a dungeon takes strength, smarts, and reflexes. Coming out a little richer than you were going in also takes luck.

The rules of *Crows* are inspired by some incredible games that are also worth your time and money. Check out *Apocalypse World*, *The Black Hack*, *Cairn*, *Knave*, *Mausritter*, *Shadowdark*, and *Troika*!

Cornath Optional

The rules refer to the land of Cornath, the campaign setting where the dungeons included with *Crows* are set. The Ref can use just the rules of this game to creature their own monsters, dungeons, items, traits, backgrounds, and campaign setting and ignore the lore of Cornath.

Welcome to Cornath

Cornath wasn't always this way. Marigolds bloomed in fall, winters were mild, songbirds twittered in spring, and summers passed hot and pleasant. The Archmages ruled together, using magic to ensure their people would prosper. These same leaders tore Cornath asunder.

For all their knowledge, the Archmages failed to see that magic, the stuff of chaos, was sentient. Tired of being used by the Archmages, magic retaliated, causing tragedy for each. The Archmages reached too far, using magic to correct their errors until chaos poisoned their souls and made them wicked.

As greed and suspicion shrunk their hearts, the Archmages raised armies of the dead, summoned monsters from other worlds, and twisted animals and plants to create hungry amalgamations. Their forces warred, uncaring for the innocent people caught in a tide of blood. The powerful spells of the Archmages suffused the land with a toxic fog that turns good folk cruel. The people gave their leaders a new name—Necromancers.

Fifty years ago the war began. Ten years ago, the Necromancers disappeared, but their beasts remain. Survivors, who huddled together in ruins during the war to keep monsters at bay, ventured into the Miasma to find others. Humans reconnected and renewed trade. The roads are overgrown and perilous, but the chance to make coin has merchants traveling and gave rise to the crows—scavengers brave or foolish enough to pick over the bones of the dead in monster-infested holes. The crows hope that each new ruin they enter holds wealth waiting to be unveiled by torchlight. Many find only death.

Amaryll

Amaryll the Generous, virtuoso with elemental magic, created spells that helped control the weather and grow crops. To feed an expanding populace, she cast a spell to make the sun shine with greater nourishment. The magic failed, scorching crops. To make up for the shortage, she created new supernatural plants ... that were more interested in eating humans than being food. Amaryll didn't see their creation as a blunder, but rather as an improvement over humans. Her monsters were evolved creature who deserved to inherit the earth from humans.

Craelin

Craelin the Clever, master of alteration magic, created spells to shape the lands and enhance the construction of Cornath's buildings. While raising a wall to protect Elsgeth City, his spell caused a massive earthquake. Desperate to make up for his folly, Craelin searched for survivors but found only corpses. He vowed to give these remains new life. Twisting their flesh with that of living animals, Craelin created the blood monsters, unnaturally transmuted creatures who hunger for human flesh. Craelin believes the other Archmages engineered Elsgeth's fall.

Ithnagio

Ithnagio the Curious, authority on conjuration magic, created spells for teleportation and to bring forth helpful creatures. While crafting a spell, Ithnagio sent his notes into Hell. He tried to bring them back but instead conjured demons. Ithnagio found he could command the evil fiends like other summons. He continued to conjure them, unaware their presence corrupted his soul.

Ornassa

Ornassa the Wise, expert in benefaction magic, created spells to heal Cornath's sick and injured. Her brother, Malek, fell ill, and no spell in her library could save him. When all seemed lost, new spells stirred in her mind. Malek became the first of many undead creatures under her command. To her, necromancy was a chance to reunite people with their loved ones ... more powerful than any benefaction spell, for it could reverse even death. Ornassa believed the other Necromancers were behind her brother's death.

Zaziel

Zaziel the Cunning, specialist in illusion magic, created spells to entertain Cornath. The last of the Necromancers to fall, Zaziel prayed to the gods for a way to save their former allies, enacting a great illusory performance meant to move the divine into action. Those illusions came to life, beautiful tangible beings that Zaziel called angels, for the mage believed they were servants of the gods. Every illusion cast brought forth a new angel, and soon Zaziel had an army and a plan. They alone must rule Cornath.

The Gods

While the people of Cornath revered the Archmages as leaders, they worshiped an even higher power—the gods. Though each god has priests dedicated to their service, most folk in Cornath pray to all five at some point throughout the day—the Gardner for good weather or harvest, the Barber to remove a loved one's ailments, the Smith for inspiration, the Warrior for protection, and the Three for knowledge, wealth, or easy passage into death. The Archmages saw priests as valuable leaders of their communities, so they gave them spells that reflected the gods' most virtuous values.

The Gardner

Depicted as a rabbit, the Gardner is the god of animals, plants, weather, and natural phenomenon. Priests of the Gardner often wear clothing of green and offer blessings at farms.

The Healer

Depicted as a leech, the Healer's domains are health and medicine. Priests of the Healer wear red, heal the injured and sick, and deliver babies.

The Smith

Depicted as a beaver, the Smith is the god of creativity. The Smith's priests bless forges, musical instruments, paints, and all manner of tools and artisans. These gold-robed priests curate and display great works of art in temples.

The Warrior

Depicted as a wolf, the Warrior is the god of battle. The Warrior's priests wear blue and bless weapons, armor, and soldiers and often take on important roles in a town's militia.

The Three

Depicted as three-headed crow, the Three is the god of death, greed, and knowledge. The Three's priests conduct funeral services and maintain temple libraries. They provide services of interest to crows, using magic to retrieve items lost in dungeons and exchanging unwanted treasures for more useful stuff. The Three's priests uniquely use necromancy magic, believing it is the wielder and not the art that makes a practice evil.

Players and the Ref

Most of the players in this game create and control an adventurer, called a crow or player character (PC for short). The *Player's Guide* has rules for making crows. The crows work together to obtain loot by delving into monster-infested ruins. These crows are from the same village, and the spoils they bring back allow them to turn their small town into a bustling fortress.

One player is the Referee or Ref. They don't play a crow. Instead, they control all the monsters, other characters (called nonplayer characters or NPCs), and environments that come into contact with the crows. The Ref also serves as the interpreter and adjudicator of the game's rules. They aren't adversarial, even though they control the crows' adversaries. Refs are impartial judges, hence the name.

To play the game, the Ref sets the scene whenever the PCs enter a new place or a new event occurs. Then the players tell the Ref what their crows do in the scene. The Ref decides if the PCs' actions require any tests and then interprets and narrates the outcome of their actions. Rinse and repeat.

The Ref is a player of the game, but from here on out whenever the rules refer to "players," we mean the ones controlling individual crows and not the Ref to avoid confusion.

Playing the Game

If you're a player controlling a crow, you should keep the following in mind as you play. If you players don't read the books, make sure they read this so they understand what they're getting into:

- **Death is on the table.** The odds are against you, so don't get too attached to your PC, and if they die, that's just part of the fun of the game. You'll have a good story to tell. That's what RPGs are all about. If you want to minimize risk of death, approach obstacles with caution. Don't run full tilt with your sword drawn at every monster you encounter.
- **Enter the dungeon.** Caution is a crow's friend. Inaction is the enemy. Standing still or checking every inch of a dungeon for traps wastes time and resources. Go slow and you will face a wandering monster as your torch burns out.

- **Think outside your character sheet.** If you approach problems logically and creatively, you might overcome them without needing to make a test at all. Any time you roll the dice, you're taking a risk.
- **Embrace failure.** This is a risky game where your PC could die. Embrace the fun of that danger. Drive your crow like you stole it, and if you end of as monster food, congratulations. You get a new PC and have a funny story to tell.

Running the Game

The Ref role is a rewarding and entirely different experience from the players in *Crows*. You control how the NPCs, monsters, and world react to the PCs' actions. As you run *Crows*, here are some tips to keep in mind that will make your game more enjoyable for you and the players:

- **Let logic and creativity win.** When the crows plan and take actions that should allow them to overcome obstacles with ease, award their forethought and ingenuity with success. There's always one more monster or hazard in the next chamber to challenge them and keep them on their toes.
- **Not every action needs a test.** If a PC attempts an action that would work more than 80 percent of the time in real life, then allow them to succeed without rolling dice. If they have lots of time to overcome a task and failure in the attempt it has no consequence, they can tackle the issue without a test. If you're used to d20 fantasy games, know that this game expects you to ask for far fewer dice rolls. Before asking for a test, really think to yourself, "Does this PC really need to make a test, or can this just work or not work without one?"
- **Hint at danger.** If the players think every square in the dungeon is a potential pit trap and that monsters lurk in every shadow, they're going to move slowly through the dungeon as they poke and prod every surface with a 10-foot pole. The game moves faster and is more fun for everyone if you telegraph when danger is ahead. A headless corpse lying in a hallway indicates the corridor might be trapped. A rotten stench seeping from under a door hints at undead on the other side. Players learn to look for these signs and when they should be on high alert, rather than constant vigilance. If they ignore the warning signs, that's on them.

- **Play the dice where they fall.** It's often best if you roll your dice in front of the players rather than in secret, because it will hold you accountable to the results. Monsters don't pull their punches. Traps are indifferent to the feelings of those who trigger them. The world of *Crows* is unforgiving, and you play the world. You should be strict but fair in your judgments. You don't need to fudge the rules in favor of the crows. They know the risks.
- **If it's fun, then it's right.** As long as you and your players are having fun playing *Crows*, then you're playing it right. Change any rules or details you like to suit your group. Your rulings are more important than the game's rules.

Dice

This game uses ten-sided dice (also called d10s). Each player and the Ref should have two of these. The game also makes use of six-sided dice (d6s). Everyone should have a few of those too.

To roll a d100, grab 2d10. One die represents the tens digit, with the other die represents the ones digit. A 10 counts as 0, unless both dice rolled are 10, then the number rolled is 100.

Game of Exceptions

This game has a fair number of rules. It also has plenty of character options, specialized equipment, and other game elements that let you break those rules. Breaking the rules makes players feel special and their foes feel dangerous.

If you're not sure what to do when two rules come into conflict with each other, a specific exception always beats a more general rule. The Ref has the final say in how rules are adjudicated.

Always Round Down

Sometimes the rules tell you to divide a number in half or by another measurement. Whenever you divide and it results in a decimal, round the result down to the nearest whole number.

Can I Be a Dwarf?

Cornath has no fantasy ancestries, but you be a dwarf, elf, orc, or whatever you like if the Ref allows it. These ancestries don't have special rules or traits which make them mechanically different than humans. It's just their appearance and story.

Creature and Object

This game uses the terms "creature" and "object" when referring to the targets of attacks, spells, and other effects. Creatures are living or unliving beings such as animals, humans, and undead. Objects are inanimate matter such as torches, ropes, and swords.

When a creature dies, their body becomes an object, and is affected by rules as an object, not a creature. If a spell targets a creature, it can't be used to target an inanimate corpse.

The game sometimes refers to "unattended objects," which are objects that aren't held, worn, or controlled by a creature. Whenever an rule targets objects, it affects only unattended objects unless the Ref determines otherwise.

You don't have to worry about effects dealing damage to ceilings, floors, walls, buildings, caves, or other structures unless the rules say otherwise.

Characteristics

Every creature in the game, including each PC, has three characteristics:

- **Agility (A):** Agility represents a creature's coordination and nimbleness. It's used for dodging, attacking with ranged and light weapons, acrobatics, sneaking, and thievery.
- **Mind (M):** Mind represents a creature's mental acuity. It's used to resist mind-bending magic, cast spells, notice hidden or secret things, or recall lore.
- **Strength (S):** Strength represents might and brawn. It's used for resisting poison and forceful effects, making melee attacks, climbing, jumping, lifting, swimming, and throwing.

Each characteristic has a score between -5 and 5. The higher your score, the better you are at the things that characteristic represents. PCs start with a score between -1 and 2 in each of these characteristics. The highest score a PC can have in a characteristics without magic help is 4.

No Interaction Characteristic

You may have played some games where there have been rules that govern and statistics for social interaction between PCs and NPCs. Social interaction isn't a focus of this game—many of an crow's foes can't or won't be reasonable. We didn't want to create a lot of social interaction expertises and traits that PCs would take and not use. Social interaction can be played out with the PCs and NPCs talking normally. The Ref decides if any persuading, bribes, lies, threats, or other techniques work on based on the NPCs' personality. If the Ref wants the dice to decide if a PC outwits an NPC, they can use a Mind test.

Magic and Mundane

The word “magic” describes creatures, objects, and effects that are magical in nature. The word “mundane” describes creatures, objects, and effects that aren't magic.

Tests

Whenever a crow performs a risky task with a reasonable chance of failure, the Ref should call for a test. If there's no reasonable chance of failure (e.g. a PC attempts to tie a simple knot with zero time pressure), the Ref shouldn't have the player make a test. If there's no chance of success (e.g. a PC attempts to hold their breath for an hour), the Ref shouldn't have the player make a test and simply describe the consequences of such an outrageous action. If it's the kind of task that would definitely result in a PC's death, the Ref should first ask the player if they're sure they want to try something that would spell their demise before they undertake the task. The Ref should make it clear the task will 100% result in bad shit happening. If the player still wants to do it, that's on them.

Clever actions taken to overcome obstacles don't require a test. They just work.

Making a Test

When the Ref decides a test is in order, the player rolls 2d10 and adds one of their crow's characteristic that the Ref deems applies to the task. If the PC attempts to sneak by a distracted monster, the test uses Agility. If they try to determine the nature of a magic glyph, the test uses Mind. If they attempt to lift an iron portcullis, the test uses Strength.

If the rules call for a test and present multiple characteristics to choose from, the creature making the test chooses which to use.

Test Results

Every test has the following possible outcomes.

Tier 1 (11 or Lower)

If the result of the test is 11 or lower, it's a tier 1 result. This result means that you didn't do what you set out to do, and at the Ref's discretion you might suffer a set back. It depends upon the nature of the test. Failing to recall lore about a god results in no consequences, while failing to jump over a pit of acid means you're going for a sizzling swim. In the case of casting some spells, a tier 1 result still accomplishes something, because the tier 1 result of spells always have a cost.

Tier 2 (12 to 16)

If the result of the test is 12 to 16, it's a tier 2 result. This result means you either partially, but not fully, accomplish your task or succeed fully at a cost. The Ref decides the outcome. If you get a tier 2 result while attempting to sneak by a monster, a partial result would be that you successfully sneaks halfway to your destination, but fail to make it out of danger, and need to continue rolling to sneak. If the Ref decides instead it makes more sense for you to succeed at a cost, you get to their destination without being noticed but drop a piece of equipment on the ground on the way.

Tier 2 results can be the most difficult for some Refs to create on the fly, since many other RPGs use a binary pass/fail system. Embracing partial success and complications is where a lot of the risk and fun of *Crows* comes in.

The following results make for interesting tier 2 results:

- An attempt to recall lore provides some useful information, but not every single detail that might help the character.
- A PC scaling the side of a cliff reaches the top, but drops a knife they carry on their belt.
- A PC chased by four wolves runs through a maze of trees, attempting to lose their pursuers in the twists and turns. They lose two of the predators, but the others nip at their heels.
- A PC chased by an undead leaps across a chasm, barely making it to the other side. They stumble upon landing, and fall prone.
- A PC lifts a stone statue to get to a trap door beneath. As they raise the heavy object into the air, they take 2 P dam as they strain themselves.
- A lockpick set is damaged during an attempt to pick a lock. The lock is picked, but until the equipment is repaired as a rest activity, any future lockpick attempts made with the set take a bane.
- A PC disables an arrow trap but makes a lot noise, drawing the attention of a nearby demon, who roars and then starts moving in the direction of the sound, giving the crows a few precious moments to react.

Tier 3 (17 or Higher)

If the result of the test is a 17 or higher, it's a tier 3 result. This means you do what you set out to do without any complication.

Crits and Dooms

When the dice without any modifiers equal a 19 or 20, the result of the test is a critical success (or crit). When you get a crit, you get a tier 3 result (regardless of banes or other penalties) plus a bit extra, which could be due to your great skill or a lucky break. If you achieve a crit while searching a chest for traps, you find and disarm any traps without another test. A crit while climbing a cliff might mean you can carry an ally who then doesn't need to make the test.

When the dice without any modifiers equal a 2 or a 3, the test result is a doom. You automatically gets a tier 1 result (regardless of edges, expertises, and other bonuses) and suffers a major setback. A doom while searching a chest for traps means you triggered the trap automatically suffers the

brunt of it without a chance to dodge the danger. Doom on a test to climb a cliff means you climb to the top of the cliff and then fall.

Unless otherwise noted, the Ref decides the exact outcome of crits and dooms.

Trying Again

When you make a test, you can't attempt it again unless the circumstances of the test significantly change. If you attempt an Agility test to pick a lock and fail, you can't attempt to pick the lock again unless you get better lockpicks, oil the lock, or the like. The Ref decides when circumstances have changed enough for a new attempt.

Edges and Banes

Edges and banes represent the circumstantial advantages and disadvantages a that creature has on a test.

Edge

An edge represents a situational advantage a creature has when making a test. A creature who makes a test to leap across a chasm from a higher cliff to a lower one has an edge. Making a melee attack a prone creature while you're standing gives you an edge on the attack.

When you make a test with an edge, you gain a +2 bonus to the roll. If you make a test with two or more edges, you have a double edge. With a double edge, you don't add anything to the power roll, but the outcome of the test automatically improves one tier (to a maximum of tier 3).

Bane

A bane represents a situational disadvantage a creature has when making a test. A rainstorm gives you a bane on a test made to climb an outdoor wall because the weather makes the stone surface extra slick. An Agility test made to walk across a narrow ledge while drunk takes a bane.

When you make a test with a bane, you take a -2 penalty to the roll. If you make a test with two or more banes, you have a double bane. With a double bane, you don't subtract anything from the test, but the outcome of the test automatically decreases one tier (to a minimum of tier 1).

Tests with Edges and Banes

Under certain circumstances, you might have one or more edges and banes on the same test. For instance, you might take a bane when weakened by poison, even as you gain an edge for striking a prone creature. In general, edges and banes cancel each other out, resolving as follows:

- **If you have an edge and a bane, or if you have a double edge and a double bane,** the test is made as usual without any edges or banes.
- **If you have a double edge and just one bane,** the test is made with one edge, regardless of how many individual edges contribute to the double edge.
- **If you have a double bane and just one edge,** the test is made with one bane, regardless of how many individual banes contribute to the double bane.

Bonus and Penalties

Certain equipment, traits, assists, and other rules grant bonuses and penalties to tests. For example, masterwork blacksmith's tools grant a +2 bonus to tests made to craft weapons and armor. Unless specifically called an edge or a bane, these modifiers don't count as edges or banes when determining how many edges or banes apply to a test.

Expertise

Expertises represent a crow's training and ability to expend extra effort in specific scenarios. After you make a test, you can use an applicable expertise to improve the test's result by one tier (to a maximum of tier 3). You can only apply one expertise and one use per test.

Each expertise has a number of uses, which is determined at character creation and can be increased through character advancement (see the *Characters* booklet). You can use an expertise a number of times equal its uses. You regain all uses of an expertise when you finish a rest.

There are three categories of expertises: general, spellcasting, and weapon. General expertises apply to tests that are used in exploration, investigation, and crafting. Spellcasting expertises are only used in castings, and weapon expertises are only used in weapon attacks (see Special Tests). At the Ref's discretion, these expertises

could apply to other tests, such as identifying a spell cast by an enemy or determining the properties of a magic weapon.

General Expertises

Expertise	Use
Alchemy	Make and know about potions, poisons, and bombs
Athletics	Climb, jump, and swim
Blacksmithing	Make and know about metal tools, armor, and weapons
Enchanting	Make and know about magic items
Endurance	Remain engaged in strenuous physical or mental activity for a long time period
Gymnastics	Move across unsteady or narrow surfaces; tumble
Handle Pet	Interact with pets
Historical Lore	Know about significant past events
Lift	Pick up, carry, and throw heavy objects
Magic Lore	Know about magical places, spells, items, and phenomena
Monster Lore	Know monster ecology, strengths, and weaknesses
Nature Lore	Know about natural flora, fauna, and weather
Navigate	Travel without getting lost
Pick Lock	Open a lock without the key
Religious Lore	Know about religious mythology and practices
Search	Search an environment for important details and items
Stealth	Hide and sneak
Thievery	Disable mechanical devices, open locks, pick pockets, and general sleight of hand

Spellcasting Expertises

Expertise	Use
Alteration	Cast alteration spells
Benefaction	Cast benefaction spells
Conjuration	Cast conjuration spells
Elemental	Cast elemental spells
Illusion	Cast illusion spells
Necromancy	Cast necromancy spells

Weapon Expertises

Expertise	Use
Bashing	Attack with bashing weapons
Bow	Attack with bow weapons
Chopping	Attack with chopping weapons
Slashing	Attack with slashing weapons
Stabbing	Attack with stabbing weapons
Unarmed	Attack with natural weapons

By design, some expertises overlap. It’s plausible that three different people—one an expert in blacksmithing, one an expert in magic item enchantment, and one an expert in magical lore—could all have a decent change at identifying the properties of a magic sword.

It’s not up to the Ref to know every expertise a PC has. When a PC makes a test and wants to apply an expertise, they can tell the Ref which they are applying. If it’s not obvious why it applies, the player should make an argument. If the Ref agrees, the expertise applies. If they disagree, it doesn’t.

Approaching a problem creatively helps you get the most out of your expertises. Climb is the obvious choice for a test made to move up and over a wall, but if you balance a board diagonally on the ground to make a ramp, you might use Gymnastics instead.

You’re AN Expert

At the Ref’s discretion, having an expertise can allow you to bypass a test all together, particularly if what you’re attempting would be considered amateur hour to an expert in the field. Attempting to recall lore about a well-known monster might be a test for most folks, but not for someone with the Monster Lore expertise. They just know that stuff and only need to make a test to recall the deep lore.

Special Tests

There are three special kinds of tests.

Assist

An assist is a test you make to aid another creature with a different test. You must make the assist before the other test. You might make a Strength test to give another PC a boost while they attempt to climb up a cliff or make a Mind test to distract an enemy and give an ally a bonus on an attack. The test has these outcomes.

- ⚔11 The assisted test gains a -1 penalty.
- 12-16 The assisted test gains a +1 bonus.
- 17+ The assisted test gains a +2 bonus.

Generally, if the test you’re assisting doesn’t happen within 1 combat turn of the assist, any bonus applied to it by the assist disappears.

When you make an assist in combat, you must use your maneuver if the test you assist requires a maneuver or your action if it requires an action or reaction.

Attacks

Attacks are tests made by a creature when they intend to deal damage to another creature or an object. The results of an attack, including crits and doom, are specified by the rules and the spell or weapon used to make them. Only spellcasting and weapon expertises can be applied to attacks. See [Combat](#) for more.

Castings

Castings are tests made to cast a spell from a spellbook. The results of a casting, including crits and doom, are specified by the rules and the spell used to make them. Only spellcasting expertises can be applied to castings. See [Spellcasting](#) for more.

Some castings are also attacks. The rules of castings and attacks apply to them.

Resistance Rolls

Resistance rolls (RR) are tests a creature makes in response to danger, such as an explosion, mind-warping magic, or poison. An effect that forces a resistance roll provides its tier results.

Gymnastics is the most common expertise applied to Agility RRs and Endurance is most commonly applied to Mind and Strength RRs, but as normal, any justified expertise can apply to an RR.

A crit on an RR could allow a creature to get a chance to harm the creature or object forcing the roll (similar to a counter; see Combat) or provide an automatic tier 3 result for an ally making the same test. A doom result could mean that that the creature making the roll takes 1d10 damage in addition to any other harm imposed by the result.

Group Tests

The Ref can call for a group tests when a PC and at least one of their allies wants to engage in the same activity that requires a test at the same time. A group test is often used when a group of PCs wants to sneak by a monster or when all of the PCs decide to scale a wall or tree together. The players should pick one creature among those engaged in the group test to be the leader. Every other creature involved in the test must make an assist to help the leader's test, then the leader rolls their test, which determines the outcome for the group.

If the leader gets a tier 2 result and the Ref decides that success should come at a cost, the leader and any creature who gave them a penalty to their test suffers the cost.

Hide and Sneak

You can only make a test to hide from a creature if they aren't observing you. If you try to sneak by a creature, you must move at half your speed or slower or take a bane on the test. While you are hidden from another creature, you gain an edge on attacks against them, and they take a bane on RRs imposed by you. If you're hidden and take aggressive action, a creature notices you.

Sizes

Each creature and object in the game fits into a size category, which roughly describes their volume and weight. The Sizes table gives examples of creatures and objects of such sizes. Note that Tiny is the smallest size and Holy Shit is the largest, so these categories can contain creatures and objects that are infinitesimally little and big respectively.

Sizes

Size	Example Creature	Example Object
Tiny	Rat	Compass
Small	Lynx	Lute
Medium	Human	Heavy armor suit
Large	Grizzly bear	Cart
Huge	Elephant	Catapult
Holy Shit!	Blue whale	Barn

Inventory Slots

The number of items you can carry is represented by your inventory slots. Every PC has 2 hand slots, 4 belt slots, and 10 backpack slots, numbered 1 to 10. A PC can wear an outfit of clothes (but not armor) and a backpack without those items taking up slots.

Many items, such as a shield, a sword, or a crowbar, take up a single inventory slot. Other items, such as a ladder or a suit of heavy armor, take up more than 1 inventory slot. The inventory slots these items take up must always be of the same type and must be next to each other. You can't carry a 10-foot pole with one hand slot and one belt slot, and you can't place your 10-foot pole in backpack slots 2 and 7.

There are several items that can be stacked in a single inventory slot. An inventory slot can hold 5 potions, 3 locks, or 2 flasks of lantern oil. You can only stack items of the same kind in one inventory slot, though these items don't have to be exactly the same. You can stack up to 5 different potions together in a slot, but you can't stack 3 potions and 2 locks together. Each hand can only hold one item at a time, so you can't stack items in hand slots.

Magic Item Slots

You have six magic item slots that can be used to wear magic items.

- **Head** slot for circlets, crowns, and hats
- **Neck** slot for amulets, cloaks, and necklaces
- **Waist** slot for magic belts and girdles
- **Arms** slot for magic bracers and gloves
- **Finger** slot for rings
- **Feet** slot for boots and shoes

If a magic item must occupy a magic item slot to be used, the item's card informs you.

If you have more than one magic item equipped in the same slot, your body is overwhelmed with chaos, and you can't rest and at the end of each DT, you gain 1d6 wounds.

Item Cards

You track of your equipment using the item cards and inventory sheet that come with this game. You can use the digital files of this game to print as many cards and sheets as you need.

Each piece of equipment is represented by a card. If a piece of equipment takes up 2 slots, you can lay it horizontally to indicate the number of slots it takes up. If it takes up 1 slot, then place it vertically on the sheet. You can keep track of magic effects or the number of an item that you have in a stack by putting the card in a plastic card sleeve and writing on the card in dry erase marker, or write directly on a card you print out.

The cards can be placed on the sheet, or you can arrange them without a sheet by placing your item cards in four rows: the top row contains the cards in your hand slots, the middle row is your belt slot cards, and the bottom two rows are your backpack slot cards (5 slots per backpack row).

Wearing Armor

You can choose one suit of armor (not a shield) in your backpack slots to be the armor you currently wear. You can only don a new armor when you are not in a situation tracked in combat rounds.

Equipped Items

Aside from magic items worn in slots and suits of armor, to use any other item, including a weapon, tool, light source, or spellbook, the item must first be placed in a hand slot. Items in hand slots are equipped and being wielded.

Swapping Slots

When you aren't in combat or some other situation tracked in combat rounds, you can freely switch items between slots. When you are in a situation tracked in combat rounds, you need to use a maneuver (see [Combat](#)) to rearrange your hand slots and belt slots with each other. As part of this maneuver, you can freely drop any item you're holding or wearing on your belt.

If you want to grab an item from your backpack when time is tracked in combat rounds, you need to use a maneuver and then declare the item you want from your backpack. Then roll 1d10. If the result is equal to or higher than at least one of the backpack slots of the item you declared, you draw out the item and can swap it and any items in your hand slots, or drop the items in your hand slots and move the item from your backpack slots into your hand slots. If the number you rolled is lower, you can rearrange the items in your backpack, but you can't take anything out. You can only grab one backpack item at a time.

You can drop any number of items from your backpack onto the ground as a maneuver.

CARRYING CORPSES

A corpse takes up a number of slots equal to its size (as shown on the Corpse Slots table), plus the number of slots occupied by any equipment on the corpse.

Corpse Slots

Corpse Size	Slots Occupied	Stack
Tiny	1	3
Small	2	1
Medium	4	1
Large	8	1
Huge	16	1
Holy Shit!	32	1

*At the Ref's discretion, Holy Shit! corpses take up more slots.

Damage and Death

Every creature in the game has a measure of vitality called Stamina. Some creatures also have an Armor Defense (AD) and all PCs also measure vitality in wounds taken. Damage is sometimes abbreviated as “dam” in test results.

Armor Defense

Every suit of armor and shield has an AD. When a creature wearing armor or wielding shield takes damage, it subtracted from their armor's AD. If a creature has more than one source of AD (such as a worn suit of armor and shield), they choose which item first loses AD while taking damage. When an item's AD drops to 0, the item can no longer be used to stop damage. A PC can restore one item's AD as a rest activity (see Resting).

Piercing Damage

Some damage is designated as piercing, with a P next to the damage amount. This damage ignores AD and is subtracted from a creature's Stamina first and then grants wounds if the creature's Stamina is 0.

Stamina

When a creature's AD is 0, the damage they take reduces their Stamina. When a Ref-controlled creature's Stamina is 0, they die. If you reduce a Ref-controlled creature to 0 Stamina, you can ask the Ref if the damage could instead knock the creature unconscious. If the Ref says it's okay, then the creature is reduced to 1 Stamina instead of 0 and regains consciousness at the end of the dungeon turn.

Objects have Stamina and are destroyed when it reaches 0. They can take damage, but can't gain conditions or other effects.

Wounds

When a PC (or another human or an animal) takes damage and their AD and Stamina are 0, they take 1 wound for every 1 damage they take. Each wound they take fills up a backpack slot of the PC's choice. For each slot occupied by a wound and an item, your speed is reduced by 1 (to a minimum of 0). When all of a creature's backpack slots have wounds, they die.

Conditions

Conditions are temporary status effects that can harm or help a creature. You can't gain a second instance of a condition you already have.

Blessed

While you are blessed, you gain an edge on all tests and attacks you make deal additional damage equal to the characteristic used to make the attack. You lose this condition at the end of a dungeon turn.

Grabbed

You can be grabbed by a creature, effect, or object. While you are grabbed, your speed is 0, you can't flank, and attacks against you gain an edge. If your grabber moves, you move with them. If the grabber is your size or smaller, their speed is halved while they have you grabbed. The grabber can use a maneuver to change your position relative to them, as long as you remain within range of the effect that grabbed you relative to the grabber's current position.

If the grabber moves further away from you than the range of the effect that grabbed you, you are no longer grabbed. The grab ends if the grabber willingly lets go or is killed, prone, or unconscious. You can attempt to end the grab with the Escape Grab maneuver (see Common Maneuvers in Combat).

PRONE

While you are prone, you are lying on the ground and your speed is halved. You take a bane on melee attacks, you can't flank, melee attacks against you gain an edge, and ranged attacks against you take a bane. You can drop prone on your turn in combat (no action required). You can stand up from prone and end the prone condition as a maneuver long as your speed is 1 or higher.

Vulnerable

While you are vulnerable, each time you take damage you take an additional 1d6 dam. You lose this condition at the end of a dungeon turn.

UNCONSCIOUS

While you are unconscious, you are asleep (and when you sleep, you are unconscious). You're prone, your speed is 0, you can't take actions, maneuvers, or reactions, automatically get a doom result on all Agility and Strength tests, and have a double bane on Mind tests made to notice anything about your surroundings. Attacks against you always achieve a tier 3 result (though the attacker can roll to see if they get a crit). If you take any damage while unconscious, you wake up and the condition ends. A creature who makes a loud noise, like shouting, wakes up each sleeping creature within 10 squares of them, ending this condition on those creatures.

WEAKENED

While you are weakened, you take a bane on all tests. You lose this condition at the end of a dungeon turn.

Usage Dice

Certain equipment, spells, and other effects have a finite number of uses or a duration tracked in usage dice (UD). All UD are d6s. When the rules tell you to roll UD, roll all of the item or effect's dice. If a die rolled is a 1 or 2, that die is removed from the item or effect's UD total. When an effect's UD is 0, it ends. An effect's UD are always rolled at the end of each dungeon turn.

Equipment Usage Dice

If a piece of equipment has usage dice, it is noted as a "UD" entry on its card.

- If the item's UD entry contains "Useless," the item is permanently useless after its UD are 0.
- If an item's UD entry contains "Refuel," then its maximum number of UD are restored when a PC uses the item indicated in the UD entry to restore it. For instance, it takes a pint of oil to restore a lantern's 2 UD.
- If an item's UD entry contains "Rest," then it's maximum number of usage dice are restored when the PC carrying it finish a rest.
- If an item's UD entry contains "Activate," you should roll its usage dice whenever you use the item as specified on its card after resolving any initial effects the item's activation creates.
- If an item's UD entry includes "DT," then you

should roll its usage dice at the end of each dungeon turn.

DUNGEON TURNS

Dungeon exploration occurs when the PCs explore a ruin, fortress, cave, or other location room by room. The rules generally refer to these locations as "dungeons."

When the PCs enter a dungeon, the first dungeon turn (DT) begins. Each DT is 30 minutes of real-world time. The Ref should track this time on their phone or some other timer and share the clock with the players. The timer shouldn't be stopped unless the group takes a break from play or if the Ref wants to pause to explain or look up the rules.

Searching a shelf of books might take 5 minutes of fictional game time but less than 30 seconds to resolve in the real world. A combat encounter might last only 1 minute in the game, but take 20 minutes to play out. Don't adjust the real-time of DTs to correlate to any specific amount of fictional time while in a dungeon. The effects that rely on a DT tend to be dramatic and unpredictable. When will a monster find us in this place? How long will this torch last? When will I shake off the effects of this poison?

END OF A DUNGEON TURN

At the end of a DT, PCs roll UD for items or effects, and the Ref should roll for an encounter (see [Dungeon Encounters](#)). Then another DT begins.

GREED BONUS

The Three rewards crows who venture bravely into dungeons and place greed over caution. The deity blesses treasures found quickly, increasing their value. If the PCs find treasure in the first three DTs of entering a dungeon for the first time, the treasure increases in value based on the turn in which it was found.

- **1st DT:** 30%
- **2nd DT:** 20%
- **3rd DT:** 10%

This increase can't apply in that dungeon again to the group (or another group of PCs played by the same players).

Outside the DUNGEON

Sometimes you want to use an item or spell with a duration tracked in UD rolled at the end of a DT outside of a dungeon. Maybe you're traveling through the woods at night carrying a torch, how do you know when it burns out? When not in a dungeon, you can consider every 2 hours of in-fiction time equivalent to a DT.

Adjusting DT Time

In testing, the rules for dungeon turns have proved to be many people's favorite part of the game. If you're skeptical, we suggest you give them a try as written. For most groups 30 minutes is the right amount of time pressure to still allow for jokes and japes at the table. A minority of folks wanted either a more relaxed or a more intense pace of DTs.

If you want a more relaxed pace, you can make each DT 60 minutes of real time. If you want more intense pace, make each DT 20 minutes.

If you don't like the idea of using a real-time timer at all, you can instead have each DT end whenever the PCs explore 1d6 rooms in a dungeon, rolling at the start of each DT to determine its length.

DUNGEON ENCOUNTERS

The Ref should make an encounter check at the end of each DT and whenever the PCs do something within a dungeon that would attract a lot of attention, like making a lot of noise while breaking down a door with a hammer or setting fire to a huge tapestry and creating smelly smoke.

When the Ref makes an encounter check, they roll 1d10. If the number is equal to or higher than the encounter number (EN), then an encounter occurs (even if the PCs are in the middle of combat). The default EN for a check is 9, but the Ref can lower the number to 8 if a dungeon's level is particularly crowded with creatures (more than twenty as a guideline) or if the PCs have left an inordinate amount of chaos and disorder (such as a trail of bodies) behind them. If both of these conditions are true, decrease the EN to 7.

If an encounter occurs, the Ref should roll on the encounter tables in *The Ref Book* to determine what the PCs encounter. The table chosen should be based on the type of monsters that infest the

dungeon. If more than one type of monster is in the dungeon, the Ref chooses a table. If the Ref rolled a 10 for the encounter check, the encounter occurs immediately. On a 9 or lower, the Ref immediately grants players some sign of the coming encounter, such as a monster heard roaring in the distant halls, a fresh and half-eaten corpse, or a large footprint, and the encounter occurs at any point during the next DT of the Ref's choosing.

Resting

You can rest to regain your Stamina, lose wounds, and recharge some equipment, like spellbooks. To rest, you must spend at least 6 uninterrupted hours in-game in one place without engaging in strenuous activity, such as exploration or combat, and at least 4 of those hours must be spent sleeping. While you rest, you must consume at least 1 ration or equivalent food. At the end of a rest, you regain all your Stamina and the number of wounds you have decreases by 1. You choose which wound you lose. You also regain all the uses of your expertises, unless you are resting in the Miasma (see Miasma).

Rests take place outside of DTs. When you start a rest, your current DT ends, but the Ref doesn't make an encounter check for the end of the DT. When you are halfway through your rest, any ongoing effects that end at the end of a DT or have UD that are rolled at the end of a DT also end. A new DT starts when your rest ends (which could be because you finish it or it could be because it is interrupted by a rest encounter).

Rest Encounters

When you rest in a dungeon or out in the wilderness, the Ref should make an encounter check. If you rest in a dungeon, the Ref should use the encounter check rules for Dungeon Encounters. If you rest during overland travel, the Ref should use the rules for Travel Encounters. If rest is interrupted by combat or other strenuous activity, the PCs must start resting again from the beginning to gain the benefits of a rest.

Rest Activities

When you are not sleeping during a rest, you can engage in a light activity (usually done at the same time as being on watch while others sleep). The following rest activities are available to all PCs. Traits and other game rules grant can grant you additional rest activities. You can only perform one rest activity per rest and must complete the rest to gain the benefit of it.

Craft Equipment

You can make one crafting roll to craft an item. See [Crafting](#) for more information.

Harvest

You harvest crafting material from a monster corpse. The process destroys the corpse, and the corpse generates 1d6 parts if it is Medium or smaller, 2d6 parts if it is large, 3d6 parts if it is Huge, and 4d6 parts if it is Holy Shit.

Identify Item

Choose one item you have that is magic. You experiment with the item and learn its properties when you finish the rest.

Prepare for Task

Tell your Ref about a specific task in a specific location that requires a test that you want to prepare for, such as, "I want to prepare to pick the lock on the door in the north hall," or, "I want to prepare to scale the Cliffs of Death." If the task doesn't require or can't be accomplished with a test, the Ref should ask you to choose a new task or rest activity.

The task you choose must be something you have intimate knowledge of. For example, you must have previously interacted with a lock to prepare to pick it or know what makes scaling the Cliffs of Death tricky to prepare to climb them.

When you finish the rest, you gain a +2 bonus on tests made to perform the task. This bonus lasts until you finish another rest.

Repair Armor

You repair a suit of armor or shield you have, restoring its AD to full when you finish the rest. The armor you carry, including the slots it takes up, includes a small kit for making basic repairs.

Seclude Camp

You obscure the area where you and your allies rest, placing your belongings in accessible hiding spots, building ways to obscure your group. This activity raises the EN during your rest by 1. Only one person in a group can perform this rest activity per rest and you don't need to complete this rest to gain this activity's benefit.

Tend Wounds

Pick a creature who has at least 2 wounds who rests with you. You can't choose yourself. You spend time tending to that person's wounds. When you and that person finish the rest, they lose 2 wounds instead of 1. A creature can only benefit from this activity once per rest.

Rest Activities in Town

While in a village or other place with no chance of encounters, a PC may wish to perform multiple rest activities per day without having to sleep more than half the day away. A rest activity typically takes about 2 hours of time, and most PCs need time for sleep, meals, socializing, shopping, and other chores while in town. You can accomplish up to 4 rest activities without having to finish a rest per day while in town. Any activities accomplished this way that have effects that kick in when you finish a rest instead kick in after the 2 hours spent working on them, with one exception—the Tend Wounds activity. A creature can only benefit from the Tend Wounds activity once per day, and they only gain the benefit after sleeping for at least 4 hours after the activity is completed.

Light

Without a proper light source, a crow can't effectively navigate their environment, unlike dungeon denizens. There are three levels of light. When an item or effect sheds light, it's listed as X/Y. X is the number of squares it sheds bright light in all directions, and Y is the amount of dim light it sheds in all directions after that.

Bright Light

Bright light illuminates everything around it clearly. It's sunlight and light that emanates directly from and closest to a source like a torch.

Dim Light

Dim light poorly illuminates an environment, shrouding details in shadow, like moonlight. While attacking a target in dim light or making a test to discern details or search for something or someone, the test takes a bane.

Darkness

While attacking a target in darkness or making a test to discern details or search for something or someone, the test takes a double bane. If you are attacking a creature who is moving silently, you must guess which space the target occupies. If you're wrong, your attack automatically misses.

Campfire

When the PCs rest (or whenever they feel like it), they can build a campfire. The light a campfire sheds depends on its size, as shown in the Campfire Brightness table. At the Ref's discretion, building a Medium or larger fire takes significant time and requires a lot of wood.

Campfire Sizes

Size	Bright	Dim
Tiny	0	5
Small	5	5
Medium	10	10
Large	15	15
Huge	20	20

Dousing Light Sources

If you douse a light source that has its duration tracked in UD rolled at the end of a DT, like a torch or a lantern, roll the UD when the light is doused as well.

Common Hazards

While all manner of hazards await the crows, these are some of the most common.

Falling

When you fall 10 feet or more, you take 1d6 P damage per 10 feet fallen. You can use your reaction to make an RR to reduce the damage.

2d10 + A

- ≤11 No effect.
- 12-16 The damage is reduced by 1d6.
- 17+ The damage is reduced by 2d6.

Starvation

Each day a you go without eating at least 1 ration worth of food, you gain a starvation wound. A starvation wound functions like a normal wound, except that you remove all starvation wounds when you eat 1 ration or equivalent food.

Suffocation

If you can't breathe, the Ref tracks your time and movement in combat rounds. You can hold your breath a number of combat rounds equal to 3 + your Strength. At the start of each round after this that you can't breathe, you take 1d6 dam.

Line of Effect

To target a creature or object with an attack, spell, or other effect, you must have line of effect to that target. If any solid object, such as a wall or pillar, completely blocks the target from you, then you don't have line of effect.

If you're not sure whether you have line of effect to a target, imagine drawing a straight line from any corner of the space you occupy on an encounter map to any corner of a space the target occupies (see [Size and Space](#)). If one or more corners of your space connect to any corner of the target's space with no obstruction in between, you have line of effect to the target.

At the Ref's discretion, flimsy or fragile obstructions such as a glass window or linen curtains don't block line of effect, and might be automatically broken or torn by attacks, spells, or other effects used through them.

If you create an environmental effect, such as a portal, you must have line of effect to the space where you create the environmental effect.

Cover

When you have line of effect to a creature or object but that target has at least half their form blocked by a solid object such as a tree, wall, or overturned table, the target has cover. You take a bane on attacks made against them.

Concealment

Fog, rain, and other obscurments that don't protect a creature's physical form are called concealment.

Light Concealment

Light concealment doesn't totally obscure vision. While attacking a target in it or making a test to discern details or search for something or someone, the test takes a bane.

Heavy Concealment

Heavy concealment totally obscures vision. While attacking a target in it or making a test to discern details or search for something or someone, the test takes a double bane. If you are attacking a creature who is moving silently, you must guess which space the target occupies. If you're wrong, your attack automatically misses.

Invisibility

If you are invisible, you are treated as if you are in heavy concealment.

Combat

Most crows don't seek out fights, but when you're cornered by undead in a dungeon or find a horde of blood monsters between you and a pile of gold, it's time to draw steel. Approach combat with caution. Death is always an option.

Combat happens in rounds. During each round of combat, each combatant gets a turn to act. The round ends after all combatants have had a turn and a new one begins until all the combatants left decide or are forced to stop fighting.

Grid and Distance

Combat uses miniatures and a grid. Distances are measured in squares on the grid. For ease of play (and defying Pythagoras), diagonal distances are measured the same as non-diagonal distances.

Scale

Each square on the grid measures 5 feet across.

Size and Space

Each creature has a size that describes how many squares they occupy on a grid as shown on the Creature Size table. The number of squares a creature takes up are referred to as their space.

You can't occupy the space of another creature within 1 size category of you. You can move through the space of other creatures but can't stop in them. Spaces occupied by enemies are difficult terrain (see [Difficult Terrain](#)).

Squeezing

At the Ref's discretion, a creature can squeeze themselves into a space smaller than what they normally occupy. While squeezed, their speed is halved and attacks against them gain a +1 bonus.

Reach

Your reach is determined by your size as shown on the Creature Sizes table. Your reach determines the distance in squares you can be away from a creature or object and still target it with melee attacks and other effects that specify using your reach. Humans are Medium sized and have a reach of 1. Some weapons extend your reach when you make attacks or counters with those weapons (and only when making attacks and counters with those weapons).

Creature Sizes

Size	Squares	Reach
Tiny	1	1
Small	1	1
Medium	1	1
Large	2 × 2	2
Huge	3 × 3	2
Holy Shit!	4 × 4*	3

*At the Ref's discretion, Holy Shit! creatures can be even bigger.

Surprised

If combat begins with one or more creatures unaware of the others, those creatures are surprised. Surprised creatures can't take a turn and attacks against them gain a +1 bonus. After the first round of combat, surprised creatures are no longer surprised.

Who Goes First?

At the start of each round of combat, a player of the Ref's choice should roll 1d10. If the result is a 6 or higher, the PCs and any NPC allies they have can take their turn followed by their enemies, and vice versa if the result is 5 or lower. Players determine the order in which the PCs and their allies take turns, and the Ref determines the order of their enemies. This roll is repeated at the start of each round.

Turn

On your turn, you can take a maneuver and an action or use two maneuvers. You can also choose to only take one action or one maneuver or do nothing. You can't break up your turn with another creature's turn.

Most actions you can take are determined by their equipment and traits. The most common action is to make an attack with a weapon or a spell (see [Making Attacks](#)).

Common Maneuvers

The following maneuvers are available to all creatures. Some equipment or traits give you access to other maneuvers.

- **Move Speed:** You move a number of squares up to your speed. You can break up this maneuver with your action or another maneuver.
- **Shift:** Move 1 square without provoking opportunity attacks (see [Opportunity Attacks](#)).
- **Command:** You command a pet you control to use an action or maneuver. See [Pets in Combat](#).
- **Draw From Pack:** You attempt to draw an item from your backpack (see [Swapping Slots](#)).
- **Draw From Belt:** You draw an item or two from your belt (see [Swapping Slots](#)).
- **Pick Up Item:** You pick up an unattended item within your reach, provided you have enough hand slots free to grab it.
- **Dump Backpack:** You drop any number of items from your backpack onto the ground.
- **Stand Up:** You must be prone and have a speed of at least 1 to use this maneuver. You stand up.
- **Grab:** You can make the following test, targeting one creature of your size or smaller within your reach. You can only grab one creature this way at a time.

2d10 + S

- The target can counter.
- Push 1 or you can take the Shift maneuver.
- The target is grabbed by you.

- **Escape Grab:** If you are grabbed, you can make the following test to wrestle your way out of the grasp of your grabber.

2d10 + A or S

- The grabber can counter.
- You can choose to be no longer grabbed, but if you do, the grabber can counter.
- You are no longer grabbed and can move 1 square without provoking opportunity attacks.
- **Knockback:** You can make the following test, targeting one creature of your size or smaller within your reach.

2d10 + S

- The target can counter.
- Push 1
- Push 2

Taunt Action

As an action on your turn, you can choose a creature a creature within 10 squares of you. That creature has a bane on attacks that don't include you as a target until the start of your next combat turn.

Ready an Action

You can use your action to ready a specific action or maneuver that activates when a trigger you name is met. You might say, "I'm going to use my sword to attack the next enemy who moves within 1 square of me," or, "I'm going to cast the *minor healing* spell on Boris next time he takes damage." When the trigger you specified occurs, you can use your reaction to execute the action or maneuver. If the trigger hasn't occurred by your next turn, you must ready the action or maneuver again to be able to use a reaction to execute it. See [Reactions](#) for more information.

Boring Stuff

Boring stuff, like opening an unlocked door or nocking an arrow, requires no maneuver or action unless the Ref deems otherwise.

Making Shit Up

If you want to do something impactful that isn't specified in the rules, tell the Ref. Your Ref decides if the task requires a maneuver or an action and what, if any, test needs to be made.

Making Attacks

There are two kinds of attacks: melee attacks and ranged attacks, which can be made with either weapons or spells. When you make an attack, it must be made with a weapon or spellbook you are wielding. That equipment tells you if the attack is melee or ranged, what sort of test is required, and how much damage it deals at each tier to its target.

When you make an attack with a weapon (also called a weapon attack), you can apply the appropriate weapon expertise to improve the test result. When you make an attack with a spell (also called a spell attack), you can apply the appropriate spellcasting expertise.

When you get a tier 1 result on an attack, you deal no damage or other effects to your target, and there's another potential consequence

depending on if the attack was melee or ranged. A tier 1 result on an attack is called a miss. A tier 2 or 3 result on an attack is called a hit.

Thrown weapons, like daggers, allow you to make a melee or ranged attack. When you make an attack with this weapon, you decide before you make the test if it is melee or ranged.

Melee Attacks

To make a melee attack against a creature or object, they must be within reach of the weapon or spell you wield. If you miss, the target of the attack can counter (see [Counter](#)).

All creatures can make an unarmed strike as the following melee attack. Unarmed strikes include punching, kicking, headbutting, and the like and attacks made with objects that aren't normally used as weapons (such as torches or books). Fragile objects, such as lanterns, break after being used as a weapon in an attack.

2d10 + A or S

(≤11) The target can counter.

(12-16) 1 + A or S dam

(17+) 2 + A or S dam

Ranged Attacks

To make a ranged attack against a creature or object, they must be within a number of squares equal to the range of the weapon or spell you wield. A ranged weapon attack can go further, and takes a -2 penalty for every 1 square the target is beyond normal range. Weapons with only a melee range are technically ranged 0.

If you miss on a ranged attack and the target was adjacent to one or more allies, roll any die. On an odd result, the attack hits one of those allies chosen randomly by the Ref. You deal the tier 2 damage of the weapon you made the attack with to that ally.

If your rolled a doom on a ranged attack while at least one ally is adjacent to your target, you hit one of those allies, randomly chosen by the Ref, and deal the tier 3 damage of the weapon.

If you make a ranged attack against an adjacent creature, the attack takes a bane.

Ammunition used in a ranged attack is destroyed. Thrown weapons can be recovered.

Improvised Weapons

Improvised weapons deal damage as if they are unarmed attacks. At the Ref's discretion, non-weapon objects that resemble a weapon, like the way a crowbar is similar to a hammer, can deal damage as if they are that weapon, without any special weapon qualities, however, the wielder takes a bane on such attacks with the item.

Crits on Attacks

When you get a crit on an attack, you get an another action that you must use immediately if this action is gained on a turn other than yours. If this action is gained on your turn, you can use it at any time during the turn it was gained.

Multiple Targets

Unless noted otherwise, an attack targets one creature or object within its reach or range. If an attack can target more than one creature or object, you choose which creatures to target and make one attack that applies to all targets. Any bonuses, penalties, edges, or banes apply that apply individual targets apply only to those targets, which could make the result of a single roll different for each. You can't target the same creature more than once with an attack.

Flanking

When you and one or more allies are adjacent to the same enemy and on opposite sides of the enemy, you are flanking that enemy. While flanking an enemy, you gain an edge on melee attacks against them.

You can't flank an enemy if you or the ally you're flanking with are prone, grabbed, or grabbing a creature who isn't the target.

If you're unsure whether you and an ally are flanking a foe, imagine a line extending from the center of your space to the center of your ally's space. If that line passes through opposite sides or corners of the enemy's space, then you and your ally are flanking the enemy.

High Ground

If you are at least 1 square above a target, you gain an edge on attacks against them.

Reactions

Every round, each creature has 1 reaction they can use at any point on their turn or another creature's turn. Each reaction has a trigger and can only occur when that trigger happens. A reaction always happens after the triggering event resolves. There are two common reactions, counters and opportunity attacks, available to all creatures. Some equipment or traits give a creature access to other reactions. If you get a tier 1 result on an opportunity attack, the target can't counter you.

Counter

When a creature or object within reach of a melee weapon you are currently wielding makes a melee attack against you, uses the Grab or Knockback maneuver while targeting you, or attempts to escape being grabbed by you with the Escape Grab maneuver and gets a tier 1 result, you can use your reaction to counter attack, taking advantage of the opening they gave you. If you do, you deal the tier 2 result of the weapon you're wielding to the triggering creature or object. If the triggering test result was doom, you deal the tier 3 result instead. If a creature making an opportunity attack against you gets a tier 1 result, you can't counter them.

Fighting Defensively

Counters are this game's way of fighting defensively. You'll never score big damage, but if you or your foes are suffering a lot of penalties to attacks, standing back and waiting to counter might be the way to survive a little longer.

Opportunity Attack

When a creature moves out of your reach (unmodified by a weapon), you can use a reaction to make an attack with a weapon you are wielding against them before they leave your reach. This is called an opportunity attack.

Movement

The distance you move in a single maneuver or action can't be greater than your speed. Most of the time when a creature is moving in combat, they can use the Move Speed maneuver to move a number of squares up to a number of squares equal to their speed. Easy stuff.

Difficult Terrain

Brambles, rubble, and other obstacles are difficult terrain, which is hard to move through. Entering a square of difficult terrain costs an extra square of movement. You can't jump out of difficult terrain or use the Shift maneuver to enter or while within difficult terrain.

Swimming and Climbing

Entering a square that requires you to swim, such as a lake or an ocean, or climb, such as moving up a cliff or castle wall, costs an extra square of movement. At the Ref's discretion, you might also have to make a test to see if it's even possible for you to swim or climb. If a creature has a swimming or climbing speed, then they can swim and climb at that speed without spending extra movement or needing to make a test, except for climbing upside down on ceilings. If a creature can climb upside down without needing to make a test, "(U)" will be included in their speed entry. If you are fully submerged in liquid and don't have a swimming speed, you take a bane on Agility and Strength tests.

Flying

If a creature has a flying speed, then they can move vertically and remain the air. If a creature who is flying is knocked prone or their speed is reduced to 0, they fall.

Jumping

Whenever you move, you can jump as part of that movement. The total distance you move, including jumping, can't exceed your speed. You make the following test when you jump. You gain an edge on this test if you move at least 2 squares on the same turn before jumping.

2d10 + A or S

- <11** You jump 0 squares.
- 12-16** You jump up to a distance of 2 squares with a height of 1 square.
- 17+** You can jump up to a distance equal to 2 + your Agility or Strength (minimum total distance 3 squares) with a height of 1 square.

Teleporting

When you teleport, you move from one space to another instantaneously, bypassing obstacles.

- Teleporting doesn't provoke opportunity attacks or other effects triggered by moving.
- When you teleport yourself, you must have line of effect to your destination space. When you teleport another creature, you must have line of effect from the space the teleported creature leaves and to their destination space.
- A teleporting creature's destination space can't be occupied by another creature or object.
- The effect that lets a creature teleport indicates how far they can teleport. That distance can be greater than the creature's speed.
- If you teleport while prone, you remain prone.
- If you teleport while grabbed, the condition ends for you. If you teleport while grabbing another creature, the condition ends for them.

Pets in Combat

In combat and other situations tracked in combat rounds, you could have one or more pets you own, such as a horse you ride or a goat who follows you around. These pets don't take turns of their own, but you can use the Command maneuver to have a pet you own use

a maneuver and an action or two maneuvers they can perform. The Ref has final say in what maneuvers or actions an animal can or can't take.

If you want a pet you own to do something complex or particularly dangerous, walk a complicated path or leap over a bonfire, the Ref can ask you to make the following test:

2d10 + M

- <11** The pet refuses the command.
- 12-16** The pet follows the command but is weakened after doing so.
- 17+** The pet follows the command.

Commanding a pet to attack a dangerous creature typically doesn't trigger this test, since most animals raised or purchased by crows have been trained to face monsters.

You can ride a pet you own as long as it is at least one size greater than you.

Forced Movement

Some weapons, spells, and other effects allow you to forcibly move a creature or object. There are two types of forced movement.

- **Push X:** The creature moves the target up to X squares away from them in a straight line, without moving them vertically. Each square the creature moves the target must put the target further away from them.
- **Slide X:** The creature moves the target up to X squares in any direction, except for vertically. A slide doesn't need to be a straight line.

When you force move a target, you can move them fewer squares than the number indicated. Forced movement ignores difficult terrain and never provokes opportunity attacks or other reactions or effects that involve a creature moving unless specified. There is one exception. When you force move a target into damaging terrain or into terrain that produces an effect, including a temporary magic effect, they are affected as if they had moved into it willingly.

A creature can't be force moved into a space occupied by another creature or an object. You can't use a mundane weapon or effect to force move a creature larger than you. Magical forced movement effects work on all creatures.

Vertical

If a forced movement effect has the word “vertical” in front of it, then the forced movement can move a target up or down in addition to horizontally. If a creature who can’t fly is left in midair at the end of a vertical forced move, they fall. Forced movement made against a creature who is flying is always a vertical forced move, whether or not the effect specifies it.

Non-vertical forced movement can move a target along a physical slope such as a hill or staircase. For a target to be force moved along a slope, each square of the slope can be no more than 1 square higher or lower than the previous square.

Into a Fall

If you can’t fly and are force moved across an open space that would cause you to fall, you continue moving the total distance you were moved first. If you are still in a position to fall when the forced movement ends, you fall.

Prepare for Battle

Rushing head-long into combat is a bad idea in most situations that will result in wounded or dead crows. It is a much better idea to prepare the battlefield with traps, choke points, high ground, hiding spots, or other environmental features and lure your foes into a place where you have the advantage. Of course if you can sneak by, scare, or distract your foes so you don’t need to risk a fight at all, that’s often the best course of action.

Toppling Objects

Dungeons contain statues, bookshelves, metal chests, and all manner of heavy objects that can be dropped on monsters.

When you drop an object on a creature that is their size or larger, the object does 1d10 dam to the creature plus an additional 2d10 dam for each size category the object is larger than the creature. A Huge object dropped on a Medium creature deals 5d10 dam. At the Ref’s discretion, a Holy Shit object can deal even more damage, given that there is no upper limit to the size of an object in this category.

Dropping giant objects onto other creatures is often accomplished with ropes, pulleys, crowbars, or pet elephants.

You can topple objects smaller than you with your brute strength by using a maneuver. You can attempt to topple an object of your size or up to two size categories larger than you with nothing but your brute strength with the following test. The test uses an action and takes a bane if the object is one size category larger than you or a double bane if it is two size categories larger than you.

2d10 + S

<511 The object doesn’t move.

(12-16) You can topple the object, but if you do, you take 1d6 P dam.

(17+) The object topples.

Overland Travel

Overland travel occurs when the PCs move from one location to another across vast swaths of land or explore to discover points of interest.

Hexes

Overland travel takes place in increments of hexes placed on a map. Each hex is 5 miles across. Each hex has a habitat type, such as forest, mountain, or plains, that can affect the types of encounters that can occur in the hex.

Travel Procedure

Each day that the group travels, the Ref should resolve overland travel in the following order.

1. The PCs set their travel pace.
2. Each PC and hireling declares a travel role and makes a test related to the role. Supporters make their tests first, then guides, then scouts, and finally providers.
3. The Ref rolls an encounter check during the travel day.
4. If the group reaches a destination they wish to explore, such as a dungeon or POI, then its time for Dungeon Turns!
5. When the group rests outdoors, follow the procedure for resting.
6. After resting, each human in the group makes a Mind RR to resist the Miasma.
7. Repeat the travel procedure for subsequent days of travel.

Travel Pace

At the start of each travel day, the PCs should set their travel pace as a group.

- **Slow:** The PCs travel carefully, attempting to avoid danger. They travel 1 hex today. The EN for travel and rest encounters today is 8. All tests related to travel roles gain an edge.
- **Normal:** The PCs travel at a normal pace. They travel 2 hexes today. The EN for travel and rest encounters today is 7.
- **Fast:** The PCs prioritize speed over being noticed. They travel 3 hexes today. The EN for travel and rest encounters today is 6, and tests related to travel roles take a bane.

Changing Pace

A group's overland travel pace changes based on the speed of the slowest creature traveling with the group. If a creature rides a mount or a vehicle, then they use the mount or vehicle's speed for this purpose instead.

- If the lowest speed in the group is 3 or lower, the group moves 1 fewer hexes during a travel day.
- If the lowest speed in the group is between 7 and 9, the group moves 1 more hex during a travel day.
- If the lowest speed in the group is 10 or more, the group moves 2 more hexes during a travel day.

Rivers and Roads

Roads and rivers and other bodies of water can change the travel pace of a group.

- If the group follows a road for their entire travel day, they move 1 more hex, but the EN for travel and rest encounters is reduced by 1.
- If the group crosses a river or other major body of water without the use of a water vehicle or moves upstream on a body of water, they move 1 fewer hexes during the travel day.
- If a group moves downstream on a body of water, they move 1 more hex during the travel day.

Travel Roles

Each day you travel, you can assign PCs and hirelings to the following roles.

- **Supporters:** Supporters help other roles do their job more efficiently.
- **Guide:** The guide leads the group to their intended destination. Only one creature can have this role at a time.
- **Scout:** Scouts keep an eye out for danger, shelter, or interesting things.
- **Tracker:** Trackers search for food or attempt to find specific creatures.

Aside from the guide role, you can have up to three creatures in each role, each attempting a different task within the role.

The creature assigned to the role decides which specific task they will undertake. Not everyone needs to take on a role, and any creature can choose instead to make an assist to help another creature assigned to a role.

You can leave any role vacant. The group doesn't gain the potential benefit for having someone in the role (but also avoids the potential risk that some riskier tasks can have within the role).

Supporter

In the supporter role, you take on one of the following tasks.

Fight the Miasma

You maintain the group's morale against the Miasma by getting them to share stories, play games, and the like. Make the following test.

2d10 + M

≤11 No effect

12-16 Up to four creatures of your choice traveling with you, including you, gain an edge on the RR against the Miasma today.

17+ As tier 2, but the benefit is a double edge.

Make Camp

You set up an efficient or well-protected campsite before resting.

2d10 + S

≤11 No effect

12-16 Choose one: Raise the EN during today's rest by 1 or have each creature who makes a crafting roll while at camp during today's rest gain a +2 bonus on the test.

17+ As tier 2, but the EN is raised by 2 or the crafting roll bonus is +4.

Support Everyone

You attempt to aid several different allies in completing their roles. Choose up to four allies in travel roles today, then make the following test.

2d10 + M or S

≤11 The allies take a -1 penalty to tests related to their travel roles today.

12-16 The allies gain a +1 bonus on tests related to their travel roles today.

17+ As tier 2, but bonus is +2.

Guide

In the guide role, you can take on one of the following tasks.

Follow Normal Route

You take a straight forward path to your destination. There is no risk of getting lost on this route, but it lacks the other benefits of one that does.

2d10 + M

≤11 Choose one: The group moves 1 fewer hexes than the pace you set today, or EN for travel encounters today is reduced by 1.

12-16 No effect.

17+ Choose one: The group moves 1 more hex than the pace you set today, or the EN for travel encounters today is increased by 1.

Follow Safe Route

You take a safer route to your destination, one more guarded from hazards and monsters.

2d10 + M

≤11 The group gets lost (see Lost).

12-16 The EN for travel encounters today is raised by 1 today, but the group moves 1 hex slower than the pace you set today.

17+ The EN for travel encounters today is increased by 2.

Follow Shortcut

You attempt to shave time off your journey by taking a short cut.

2d10 + M

≤11 The group gets lost (see Lost).

12-16 The group moves 1 hex faster than the pace you set today, but the EN for travel encounters is reduced by 1 today.

17+ The group moves 2 hexes faster.

Scout

In the scout role, you can take on one of the following tasks.

Scout for Danger

You move ahead of the group and look for signs of potential danger to help the group avoid it. Make the following test.

2d10 + A or M

≤11 No effect

12-16 The EN for travel encounters today increases by 1.

17+ As tier 2, but the EN increases by 2.

Scout for Shelter

You attempt to find a safe place to camp when traveling is done for the day.

2d10 + M

≤11 No effect

12-16 The EN for rest encounters today increases by 1.

17+ As tier 2, but the EN increases by 2.

Treasure Hunt

You scour the land for interesting things that might aid you on future adventures.

2d10 + S

≤11 No effect

12-16 The Ref makes a roll on the Minor Things table in *The Ref*.

17+ The Ref makes a roll on the Major Things table in *The Ref*.

Tracker

In the tracker role, you can take on one of the following tasks.

Forage

You forage for edible vegetation. Make the following test.

2d10 + M

≤11 No effect

12-16 You procure 1 ration.

17+ You procure 1d6 + 1 rations.

Hunt

You hunt edible game. Make the following test.

2d10 + A

≤11 The EN for travel encounters today decreases by 1.

12-16 No effect

17+ You procure 3d6 rations and 1d6 animal parts.

Track Specific Creature

Choose a specific animal, such as a bear, or a monster, such as blood creature B that you want to encounter. You can also choose a specific, named human. If the Ref agrees that such a creature could be found on your journey today, make the following test. If not, choose another task or role.

2d10 + M

≤11 The EN for travel encounters today decreases by 1.

12-16 No effect

17+ You encounter the creature you wish to encounter. The Ref determines when and where this happens during the day.

Lost

If the you get lost during travel, the Ref secretly keeps track of where you end up. While lost, a group doesn't know their exact position in the world.

When you travel while lost, the Ref rolls 1d6 each time the group leaves a hex during the travel day and keeps the result a secret. Starting with the northernmost adjacent hex to the one the PCs are in, the Ref counts a number of hexes equal to the result going in a clockwise direction. The number rolled is the hex the PCs actually enter. If the result is a 1, the PCs move north. If it is a 2, they move northeast.

Back on Track

At the start of a travel day when lost, the guide makes the following test to instead of one of the normal test they make to travel.

2d10 + M

- Ⓢ11 The group remains lost.
- 12-16 At the start of the day's journey, you realize where the group is on the map. You aren't lost anymore and move toward your destination at the pace set by the group.
- 17+ As tier 2, and choose one: The group moves 1 more hex than the pace you set today, or the EN for travel encounters today is increased by 1.

The group can also get back on track by finding a map, stumbling into a place they recognize that would allow them to get their bearings, or having an NPC provide directions.

Miasma

Outdoor areas in Cornath are affected by a semi-translucent, magic haze called the Miasma, which appears a little different to all creatures. Your greatest fears always seem to linger within the effect. The Miasma is the result of the spells used during the Necromancer War. It lingers outside, but can't enter indoor areas that are entirely enclosed in stone or metal. This phenomenon muddles the mind and corrupts the souls of humans, making them commit selfish and wicked acts. Too much time in the Miasma can create a permanent change.

When you finish a rest in the Miasma, you don't regain any uses of your expertises, but all of the other normal effects of resting apply.

At the end of every rest a human spends within the Miasma, they must make the following test.

2d10 + M

- Ⓢ11 The human gains a level of cruelty and must roll for a Miasma effect on the Miasma Effects table.
- 12-16 No effect.
- 17+ The human removes all levels of cruelty they have, or they improve the test result of one other human who rested with them and made this test by a tier because they helped them resist the effects of the Miasma.

For each level of cruelty you have, you take a -1 penalty to RRs against the Miasma. You lose all levels of cruelty when you finish a rest in a location that has no Miasma.

When you roll on the Miasma Effects table, you roll 1d10 + your current cruelty level and gain both effects equal to your result. The second effect lasts as long as the first. If the result is a pair of effects that is already affecting you, then roll again for a different result.

Miasma Effects

d10 + Cruelty	1st Effect	2nd Effect
1-2	You become despondent. You only speak if spoken to first and give one-word responses until you exit the Miasma.	You have an edge on tests made to sneak or hide.
3-4	You become ravenous and greedy. You must eat at least 2 rations during a rest to get the benefits of a rest until you are out of the Miasma.	Your ravenous nature makes you good at finding food. You gain a +2 bonus on tests made related to the forage role.
5-6	You enter a destructive rage and destroy one mundane item randomly chosen by the Ref from your backpack.	Destroying something makes you feel good. You regain 3 Stamina or, if your Stamina is full, lose 1 wound.
7-8	You become deceitful for the sake of it. You only communicate in lies and try to get away with it until you are out of the Miasma.	You lie even to yourself. Choose an expertise you do not have. You gain that expertise.
9-10	You become lazy. You refuse to have any travel role until you are out of the Miasma.	When you rest, you recover 2 wounds instead of 1.

d10 + Cruelty	1st Effect	2nd Effect
11-12	You relish violence. In combat, you must keep pursuing and fighting your foes until you can no longer sense them. This effect ends when you are no longer have cruelty.	Your relish in violence gives you a +1 damage bonus on weapon attacks.
13+	All of your other Miasma effects end and all your levels of cruelty disappear. You can't suffer any new Miasma effects and are permanently selfish and cruel. You become an NPC controlled by the Ref.	Finishing a rest in the Miasma regains the uses of your expertises.

ENCOUNTERS AND POIS

During overland travel, the Ref can describe the journey in a couple sentences as a simple montage. “You travel through the forest to reach your destination on a pleasant day. During the first few hours of your journey, the guide knows the way, the scout reports no trouble ahead, but the trackers find no food or game either.”

There are two instances the Ref should zoom in on the action. One is random encounters that occur during overland travel. The other is when points of interest (POIs), like unique landmarks, dungeons, and obstacles both mundane and magic, lie in the PCs’ path.

Travel Encounters

Travel encounters are run-ins the PCs have with monsters, bandits, magic phenomenon, or other travelers on the road. The Ref should roll an encounter check after the role tests are done.

Travel encounter checks follow the same rules as the checks for dungeon encounters (see Dungeon Encounters), though the EN is determined by the group's pace and the result of their tests. The EN can never be more than 10.

If an encounter occurs, the Ref should roll on the encounter tables in *The Ref Book* to determine what the PCs encounter. The Ref decides at what point during the travel day the encounter occurs.

More than one encounter or encounter check can occur during travel at the Ref's discretion. An encounter makes a particularly good choice for a

POIs

POIs are landmarks significant enough for the Ref to zoom in on the travel and play out an exploration scene. These scenes should be run using DTs. If an encounter check occurs during the exploration of the POI, use the travel day's EN for the check.

A POI should be an obstacle the PCs have to overcome to continue on their intended path, such as a river or chasm they need to cross, or a landmark they might wish to visit or investigate further. If the PCs decide to divert their path to avoid the obstacle or to not investigate the POI, that's fine!

The Ref Book has example POIs that the Ref can use or get inspired by to create their own.

Spellcasting

The Archmages fused their spells into the pages of books so academic and religious scholars could harness the magic to benefit Cornath. Though these sages were the best folks suited to the task, anyone who held one of the books could attempt to cast its spell. The more powerful the spell, the fewer times it was copied into a tome to prevent abuse and mishaps.

Spellbooks

The spell contained in the pages of a book has the following statistics.

Rank

A spell's rank form 0 to 5 that indicates its power. A higher rank means a more powerful spell.

Discipline

A spell's discipline describes the type of magic it harnesses and the spellcasting expertise than can be used for the test made to cast the spell.

- **Alteration:** Physically changes matter
- **Benefaction:** Heals and buffs creatures
- **Conjuration:** Teleports and summons creatures and objects
- **Elemental:** Harnesses the power of the air, earth, fire, and water
- **Illusion:** Creates effects that fool the senses
- **Necromancy:** Creates curses, poison, disease, and monsters

Casting Time

A spell's casting time indicates how long it takes to cast.

- **Action:** You must use an action to cast the spell.
- **Maneuver:** You must use a maneuver to cast the spell.
- **Reaction:** The spell must be cast as a reaction in response to a trigger, which will be listed in its description.
- **Out of Combat:** This complex spell can't be cast in situations tracked in combat rounds. It can be cast outside of such situations and takes 10 minutes of in-game time to cast.

Target

A spell's target indicate how many and which creatures or objects it affects.

- **Number:** The first word in a target entry is a number, typically 1, 2, or 3. This indicates the number of creatures or objects you can target with this spell. If the number is greater than 1, you can choose to target fewer creatures or objects than that number, but you can't target the same creature more than once with a single casting of a spell. If instead of a number, it says, "All" then all of the specified targets within the spell's range or area of effect (see [Area of Effect](#)) are targeted. You can't disclude valid targets when "all" are targeted.
- **Allies:** This spell targets creatures friendly to you, including yourself.
- **Enemy:** The spell targets creatures hostile to you. The Ref has final say in which creatures are hostile or friendly toward you.
- **Creature:** This spell can target any creatures other than you.
- **Object:** This spell can target any object not carried or worn by another creature.
- **Summoned:** This spell summons a creature or object within range. You can summon the target into any unoccupied space within range. If the the summoned target is an object and you have enough hand or belt slots free to hold the object, you can summon the object into those slots.
- **Target:** If a spell lists its target as "target(s)," then it can target any creature other than you or object not carried or worn by another creature. If you can target more than 1 "target," you can mix and match creatures and objects.
- **No Target Entry:** Some spells don't have a target entry. If the spell is an attack, that's because it can attack any creature or object. If the spell isn't an attack, they its description should indicate how it works without a target.

Range

A spell's range indicates the maximum number of squares you can be from a target in order to target them with the spell. The target must also be within your line of effect.

Area of Effect

Some spells target an area of effect. Instead of individual creatures or objects, they target all

creatures or objects within a specific area.

If a spell originates a distance away from you, then 1 square of the area of effect must be within that distance, and must also be within your line of effect. This square is referred to as the origin square of the area of effect. The area of effect can spread from the origin square however you choose, according to the rules for the shape and arrangement of that particular area.

You can place an area of effect to include one or more squares where you don't have line of effect, as long as you have line of effect to the origin square. Unless otherwise noted, spells don't pass through solid barriers such as walls or ceilings, and they don't spread around corners.

An spell might use any of the following areas of effect.

- **Aura X:** The number X is the radius of the aura in squares, which always originates from you and moves with you for the duration of the ability that created it.
- **Cube X:** When an spell affects a cubic area, the number X is the length of each of the area's sides in squares.
- **Line A × B:** The number A denotes the line's length in squares, while the number B equals the line's width and height in squares. When you create a line area of effect, the squares in that area must be in a straight line.

Duration

A spell's duration indicates how long any lingering effects it creates last. If a spell's caster dies, the spell ends. A caster can end a spell early (no action required).

- **Instant:** The spell exists only in the instant it is cast. The magic can put a lasting condition on a creature that has a specified duration elsewhere in the rules (such as blessed or weakened).
- **DT:** The spell lasts until the end of the DT in which it is cast.
- **UD:** The spell is maintained through a specified number of UD, which are rolled at the end of each DT. **These DT track the spell's duration, not the spellbook's usage.**

Spellbook Usage Dice

Each spellbook has 1 or more UD, which are rolled whenever its spell is cast. When the

spellbook's UD are 0, it has no magic and the spell can't be cast from its book until its usage dice are restored. A spellbook you carry regains all its UD when you finish a rest. When you get a crit on a casting, you don't need to roll the spell's UD.

Casting

Each time you cast a spell from a spellbook, you must make a Mind test. The outcomes for each casting are listed in the spell's description.

SUMMONED CREATURES

Some spells allow you to summon creatures. Unless specified otherwise, these creatures do as you command. They function like pets in combat except that you don't need to make a test to convince them to undertake dangerous actions.

Magic Backlashes

The chaotic, sentient force of magic doesn't like to be manipulated, and lashes out against those who seek to control it when their grasp of a spell is weak. A backlash happens when magic pushes back against the caster, intent on harming them.

When a backlash occurs, the Ref rolls a d100 + the rank of the triggering spell on the Backlashes table to determine the event that takes place. Backlashes occur instead of the spell that was meant to trigger them, but the caster still needs to roll the spellbook's UD.

If a backlash effect requires the spell have a target that is a creature, and the target of the spell is an object, the spellcaster becomes the target for purposes of the backlash effect. If the caster is suffering from a backlash with a duration (aside from a condition, like weakened or vulnerable), and gets that same backlash again, the Ref should roll for a different backlash unless the backlash's effects stack. UD for backlash effects are rolled at the end of each DT.

There are two ways a backlash occurs. If a creature gets doom on a casting, a backlash occurs. The second way uses the chaos roll.

Chaos Roll

The chaos roll is a 1d6 roll you make when you cast a spell from a spellbook and get a tier 1 result that isn't a doom. If the result of the chaos roll is 1, a backlash occurs.

Backlashes

d100 + Rank	Backlash
01-02	Your head transforms into a donkey's head. You can't speak, only bray at a loud volume. This effect has 1 UD.
03-04	Your magic makes you feel so good that you are compelled to dance at all times. While under this effect, your speed is reduced by 2 and you take a bane to tests made to climb, hide, sneak, or swim. This effect has 1 UD.
05-06	You summon a ghostly, self-playing accordion that can't be destroyed and follows you wherever you go and plays polka loudly until the end of this DT. It is impossible to go anywhere without notice as this accordion plays.
07-08	Each time you speak between now and the end of this DT, roll a d10. On a 10, your words unleash a thunderous boom. Each creature within 3 squares of you takes 1d6 damage. If you are already suffering this backlash, the damage increases by 1d6.
09-10	Your mood becomes fiery and irritable. If you don't harm another creature before the end of this DT, then the fire inside you makes you take 1d6 P damage. If you are already suffering this backlash, the damage increases by 1d6.
11-12	Your body temperature drops, making you very cold until the end of this DT. During this time, your speed is reduced by 1 and if you start your turn submerged in water or soaked with water, you take 1d6 P damage. If you are already suffering this backlash, then your speed is further reduced by 1.
13-14	Magic muddles your mind. You are weakened.

d100 + Rank	Backlash
15-16	Your body becomes seasoned by magic, making your bones and psyche brittle. The next time you take damage before the end of the DT, you take twice as much as you normally would.
17-18	Magic makes your body fragile. You are vulnerable.
19-20	A limb you use to hold items goes numb and can't be moved. The Ref picks one of your hand slots. You drop any item in that slot and you can't use the hand slot until the end of the DT.
21-22	Hungry magic erupts from your body and destroys the nearest 1d6 rations.
23-24	Your magic creates a thunderous boom that can be heard by all creatures within 100 squares of you. The curious ones come to investigate.
25-26	A powerful gust of wind pushes you and every creature within 10 squares of you 1d6 squares in a random direction determined by the Ref.
27-28	You infuse negative energy into yourself and take 1d6 damage.
29-30	You teleport 1d6 squares in a direction chosen by the Ref into an unoccupied space.
31-32	Shuffle your inventory cards into a deck. Roll a d10. Then pull a number of cards equal to the result from the top of the deck. The last card pulled is a piece of equipment that turns into a goat under the Ref's control. The equipment remains a goat until the goat dies, at which point it transforms back into the original equipment.

d100 + Rank	Backlash
33-34	Shuffle your inventory cards into a deck. Roll a d10. Then pull a number of cards equal to the result from the top of the deck. The last card pulled is a piece of equipment that is teleported into the possession of another creature randomly chosen by the Ref within 20 squares of you.
35-36	Shuffle your inventory cards into a deck. Roll a d10. Then pull a number of cards equal to the result from the top of the deck. The last card pulled is a piece of equipment that transforms into a feather duster until the end of this DT.
37-38	A sticky goo falls from the sky onto your body. Until this goo disappears at the end of this DT, your speed is reduced by 2. If you are already suffering from the effect of this backlash, your speed is reduced an additional 2.
39-40	A noxious, unpleasant-smelling cloud of gas forms around your head and follows you wherever you go. This gas imposes a bane on all tests. This effect has 1 UD.
41-42	You open a channel into the target of the spell's mind and their worst fears are shared with your allies within 10 squares of them. Each ally takes 1d6 P damage.
43-44	You are compelled to speak only in rhyming couplets. If you fail to do so, you take 1d6 P damage. This effect has 1UD.
45-46	Your body becomes porcelain. While in this form, whenever you take non-piercing damage, you take twice as much. This effect has 1 UD.
47-48	You are outlined in a supernatural light which makes it impossible for you to hide and easy to attack. Attacks against you gain +2 while this light is active. This effect has 1 UD.

d100 + Rank	Backlash
49-50	Fire erupts from your body. You and each creature within 2 squares of you takes 1d6 damage.
51-52	You summon open a portal that unleashes a horde of demonic bees that flit through the local area and then fly back through the portal before it closes. You and each creature within 3 squares of you must make a Might RR. ≤ 11 6 damage; weakened $12-16$ 3 damage $17+$ No effect
53-54	Tentacles erupt from your body. You and each creature within 3 squares of you takes 1d6 damage. The tentacles become nonfunctional immediately after emerging and you gain three special wounds. You or a creature who can reach you can remove a special wound's worth of tentacles from your body with a bladed tool or weapon as an action without doing further harm to you. Once all these wounds are removed, so are all the tentacles.
55-56	You summon a load of dirt that falls from the sky, smashing down on you and each creature within 2 squares of you. Each affected creature must make an Agility RR. ≤ 11 6 damage; prone $12-16$ 3 damage $17+$ No effect
57-58	Your magic summons 1d6 blood A creatures who appear in unoccupied spaces within 5 squares of you. These creatures are hostile to you.
59-60	You are so overwhelmed with emotion that you fall prone and can't stand up, crawling wherever you wish to go. This effect has 1 UD.

d100 + Rank	Backlash
61-62	Your hands become feet until the end of the DT. You gain +2 speed, but you can't hold or manipulate any objects with your hands while this effect lasts.
62-64	The ground beneath you and within 1 square of you turns to quicksand. Each creature standing on the ground must make an Agility RR. ⚔️ The creature is grappled by the sand and takes 1d6 P dam at the end of each round they are grappled. 🔗 The creature is grappled by the quicksand until the end of their next turn. 🏃 The creature can move 2 squares. A non-grappled creature who enters the quicksand or starts their turn in it must make the Agility RR. If you are not touching the ground, roll for a different backlash.
65-66	You open a one-way viewing portal that follows you around wherever you go until the end of this DT. You can't sense anything on the other side of the portal, but anyone on the other side can see and hear through the portal. The other side of the portal appears near a personal enemy or rival of the Ref's choice.
67-68	You teleport up to 50 squares away in a horizontal direction chosen by the Ref into an unoccupied space.
69-70	You take 1d6 damage and become encased in earth from the neck down and are grappled. Another creature must use an action to free you. Each time you start a combat round grappled, you take 1d6 damage.

d100 + Rank	Backlash
71-72	If the effect of the spell is good, you cast it and target the nearest enemy, regardless of the spell's range. If the effect of the spell is bad, you cast it and target yourself, regardless of the spell's range. The Ref determines if the spell is good or bad.
73-74	You get a full feeling in your stomach. At the start of each of your turns in combat, you must roll any die. On an odd result, you spend the turn vomiting slugs and can do nothing else. This effect has 1 UD.
75-76	The Ref randomly chooses 1d6 × 100 coins or a gem or other mundane treasure that you carry. It melts.
77-78	You transform into a frog. Your size is Tiny, your Stamina maximum is reduced to 1, you have 0 slots, and you lose all your expertises. You have a climb and swim speed equal to your walking speed and Jump +2. This effect has 1 UD.
79-80	Shuffle your inventory cards into a deck. Roll a d10. Then pull a number of cards equal to the result from the top of the deck. The last card pulled is a piece of equipment that is teleported off your person into a dungeon of the Ref's choice.
81-82	Your mouth and ears meld shut until you finish a rest. During this time, you can't speak or hear anything.
83-84	Your eyes become light sensitive. You treat bright light as if it were darkness. This effect has 2 UD.
85-86	You summon a cloud of buzzing, stinging insects that follow you around and don't allow you to rest until you feed them 1,000 pounds of flesh.
87-88	Your Strength score decreases by 1 until you finish a rest. This effect is cumulative.
89-90	Your Agility score decreases by 1 until you finish a rest. This effect is cumulative.

d100 + Rank	Backlash
91-92	Your Mind score decreases by 1 until you finish a rest. This effect is cumulative.
93-94	Magic bursts forth from inside your body, causing you to suffer 1d6 wounds.
95-96	Lightning flies from your body. You and each creature within 5 squares of you takes 3d6 damage.
97-98	You become allergic to magic. Whenever you or any creature activates a magic item or casts a spell within 10 squares of you, you take 1d6 P damage. This effect has 2 UD.
99-100	Whenever you cast a spell, the result is treated as one tier lower. If you get a tier 1 result, it is treated as a doom. This effect has 2 UD.
101	Antlers grow from your head. If you cut these off, they instantly grow back. You can't wear hats or any type of headgear that isn't specially modified to fit your new noggin.
102	Your mind is warped by magic. The Ref randomly chooses an expertise you have and one you don't. You lose all uses of the expertise you have and gain an equivalent number of uses of the one you do not.
103	Magic within your body reshapes one of your hands into a deadly weapon. The Ref randomly chooses a mundane 1-handed weapon. Your hand is now this weapon. You can't ever use that hand slot to hold another object.
104	Magic lighting wracks your body with pain. Your Stamina is reduce to 0 and you gain 2d6 wounds.
105	A portal to Hell opens beneath you and sucks you into it as a chorus of demons laughs at your unfortunate fate. The portal shuts as your soul and body are forever sealed away.

Crafting

While you rest or are in town, you can use to craft new equipment.

Crafting Prerequisites

You must meet an item's prerequisites to craft it.

- **Expertise:** Every craftable item has an expertise and number of uses associated with it. You must have the appropriate expertise and number of uses to craft it. This prerequisite is on the item's card.
- **Materials:** Every craftable item requires raw materials. This prerequisite is on the item's card.
- **Tools:** See below.

Tools

The tools you need to craft an item are based on the expertise needed to craft the item.

- **Alchemy:** Alchemist's tools
- **Blacksmithing:** Blacksmith's tools
- **Enchanting:** Enchanter's tools

Harvesting Materials

Some crafting materials must be harvested from a monster corpse with the Harvest rest activity. The parts are monster organs and vials of blood collected from a corpse.

Crafting Goal

Each craftable item has a crafting goal, a special number, listed on its card. The higher the number, the longer it takes to make the item.

Crafting Rolls

You can take the Craft Equipment rest activity to craft a piece of equipment you meet the prerequisites for. When you do, you make a crafting roll when you finish the rest.

A crafting roll is a special Mind test and doesn't have tiered outcomes. Instead, you calculate the total and record the result. When you make a crafting roll, the total—no matter how low—becomes crafting points that are accrued by the item you're creating. Even if you have a bane or penalty on a crafting roll, the minimum total for the roll is 1, unless you get a doom result. If you get a doom result on a crafting roll, you accrue no new points for the item. If you obtain a crit on a crafting roll, you can make another crafting roll for the same item as part of the same rest activity.

When you apply a double edge or an expertise to a crafting roll, the roll gains a +4 bonus instead of the normal benefits. You can only apply up to two expertises per crafting roll. When a double bane applies to a crafting roll, the roll gains a -4 penalty.

When all of an item's crafting points equal or are greater than its crafting goal, the item is complete and the materials used to create it are expended.

Crafting Multiple Items

If you roll high enough to finish crafting an item, you can use any surplus points to begin crafting another version of the same item, provided you have the materials. If you have enough surplus points to craft a second item, then you can begin crafting a third, and so on.

Multiple Crafters

If an creature taking a rest with you meets the tool and expertise prerequisites for an item you are crafting with the Craft Equipment activity, they can use their rest activity to undertake the task with you. Crafting rolls they make as part of this rest activity are accrued by the item as points.

Identifying Magic Items

When you encounter an unfamiliar magic item, you don't know automatically know its properties, but you can tell that it is magical, as all such items vibrate with power. To discover an item's properties, you can ask an NPC who has expertise with the item, such as asking an alchemist about a potion, or use the Identify Item rest activity during a rest. You could attempt to activate the item and see what happens. If the item is a liquid in a vial, you might drink it or pour it out on the ground to observe any effect. If it's a sword, you might swing it at a foe and see what happens. This method could waste a consumable item or have disastrous effects if the item is cursed or not fit for human consumption.

If you want to identify a magic item you hold, you can also make the following test.

2d10 + M

- ≤11 You accidentally activate the item in a harmful way determined by the Ref.
- 12-16 You learn nothing about the item.
- 17+ You learn all of the item's properties.

You can only make this test once with an item.